

A Case for He Is Not the Messiah

A White Paper of The Gospel Vault

Why Not Yeshua?

Understanding the Jewish Case Against Jesus as Messiah — Its History, and a Full Hearing

The first of a two-part set. This volume presents the case in full, on its own terms, without rebuttal. Its companion, A Case for He Is the Messiah, offers the Christian view for readers who want it.

The Gospel Vault

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I. Introduction: Purpose and Posture

This document has one job: to state, as fully and as fairly as a document produced by a Christian ministry can manage, why the great majority of Jewish people across two thousand years have looked at the claim that Yeshua of Nazareth is Israel's promised Messiah and said *no*. It is not a trap. It does not exist to be knocked down in the next paragraph — there is no next paragraph here that does that. Its companion volume, *A Case for He Is the Messiah*, exists separately for readers who want to see the Christian response. This document is not that response. It is the case itself, given room to be as strong as its own best advocates have made it.

That distinction matters for a reason beyond fairness. A Christian reader who has only ever heard the *Isaiah 53 is about Jesus* side of an argument, and never sat with the actual, textured, internally-consistent case that Isaiah 53 is about Israel, does not really understand the disagreement — he understands his own side of it. This paper is written so that the reader finishes it able to state the Jewish case in terms a thoughtful Jewish reader would recognize as accurate, not as a caricature built to be easy to beat. This writer is a Christian and welcomes additional thoughts from my Jewish friends (hopefully still) for expanded thoughts on any of the topics covered. My intent is to create a respectful dialogue is desired.

A Note on Sources

Wherever possible, this survey quotes the tradition's own primary voices directly — Nachmanides' own recorded words from Barcelona, Maimonides' own criteria in the *Mishneh Torah*, Isaac of Troki's own chapter arguments, and the contemporary published positions of Rabbi Tovia Singer, Gerald Sigal, and the organizations Jews for Judaism and Outreach Judaism. Where a source is paraphrased rather than quoted, that is noted; the governing principle throughout is the same one this ministry applies to its own theological writing: summaries must be clearly distinguished from quotations, and nothing here should misrepresent what was actually argued.

A Note on Scope

Like its companion volume, this survey begins *after* the New Testament period. It covers the post-biblical Jewish apologetic tradition — the arguments constructed once the parting of the ways between church and synagogue had hardened — not the New Testament's own record of first-century unbelief.

II. The Historical Development

The case against Yeshua's messiahship was not handed down complete. It was built, generation by generation, by real scholars responding to real pressure / questions — and it grew more careful, not less, with each stage.

A. The Earliest Layer (c. 70–160 CE)

The earliest surviving literary record of the debate is, ironically, a Christian document: *Justin Martyr's Dialogue with Trypho* (c. 155–160 CE), which stages an extended exchange with a Jewish interlocutor named Trypho over whether the prophets ever pointed to a Messiah who would suffer and be rejected rather than reign visibly. Modern scholars note Trypho is given a thin voice in a text Justin wrote and controlled — Marc Hirshman calls it “more a soliloquy than a true dialogue” — but the core Jewish position it preserves is already recognizable: prophecy describes a triumphant king, and Jesus was not one.ⁱ

Independently, later strata of the Babylonian Talmud (compiled roughly third–fifth centuries CE from older material) record a figure named Yeshu executed for sorcery and for “enticing Israel to apostasy” (*b. Sanhedrin 43a*), alongside a separate, later legendary account in *b. Gittin 56b–57a*. Scholars continue to debate exactly which passages refer to Jesus of Nazareth, but the verdict they render is unambiguous: not prophet, not sage, not Messiah — a sorcerer who deserved his execution.ⁱⁱ

B. Toledot Yeshu (6th–9th c. core)

The scattered rabbinic material above was eventually gathered into a single running counter-narrative, the *Toledot Yeshu* (“The Generations of Jesus”), likely composed in Babylonia between the sixth and ninth centuries and surviving in over a hundred manuscripts across Aramaic, Hebrew, Arabic, Persian, Yiddish, and Ladino. It answers Christianity's two most load-bearing claims point by point: against the virgin birth, it presents Mary assaulted by a neighbor, Joseph ben Pantera, making Jesus *mamzer* rather than miraculously conceived; against the resurrection, it has Jesus's body discovered by a gardener and dragged publicly through the streets. In between, his miracles are attributed not to divine power but to a stolen, misused Name of God — sorcery, not sonship.ⁱⁱⁱ Modern Jewish scholarship treats the *Toledot* as valuable evidence of what medieval polemic felt compelled to answer, not as history — but its underlying claim, that both central Christian claims about Jesus's origin and end are false, remains part of the tradition's memory even where the crude narrative form is set aside.

C. Forced Disputation: Barcelona, 1263

From the thirteenth century, Jewish scholars were increasingly compelled into public debate before hostile courts. The best documented is the *Disputation of Barcelona* (1263), where Rabbi Moses ben Nachman — Nachmanides, the Ramban — was made to answer the Jewish convert Pablo Christiani before King James I of Aragon.^{iv} Nachmanides's own summary of one of his central points, as preserved in the Jewish tradition's account of the debate, was blunt: if the Talmudic sages themselves had secretly believed Jesus was the Messiah, as Christiani claimed, that raised an obvious question — given that they, unlike anyone alive twelve centuries later, had “heard and seen him personally,” why then “did they not believe in” him “and had remained faithful Jews”? If eyewitnesses were not convinced, what obligates a Jew born over a millennium later?^v

On the specific text most often pressed against him, he held his ground plainly: Isaiah 53, he said, “speaks only of the people of Israel,” not of one man. And on the claim that redemption had already arrived in Jesus, he pointed simply to the world outside the debating hall: since Jesus's appearance the world remained “filled with violence and injustice” — whatever had happened in the first century, the Messiah's promised age plainly had not.^{vi} The king rewarded him with three hundred gold coins and praise for the defense — and then, once Nachmanides published his own transcript, Dominican pressure drove him into exile from Aragon in 1267. He died in Jerusalem. His successors drew the obvious lesson: the written page outlasts the debating hall.^{vii}

D. Systematic Polemic: Duran and Troki (14th–16th c.)

Profiat Duran (c. 1350–1415), forcibly baptized in the Spanish riots of 1391 before escaping to practice Judaism openly again, wrote from that wound. His *Kelimat ha-Goyim* (“Shame of the Gentiles,” 1397) turned his own training in Latin and medicine into a weapon, identifying what he read as internal contradictions within the New Testament and between the New Testament and later church doctrine — arguing, deliberately, *from within* the opponent's own text rather than only from the Tanakh.^{viii}

The tradition's fullest statement came from Isaac of Troki (c. 1533–1594), a Lithuanian Karaite whose *Chizzuk Emunah* (“Faith Strengthened”) organizes the entire case into two parts. The first argues the Jewish side directly: that plural Hebrew forms like *Elohim* and “Let Us make man” do not establish a Trinity; that Genesis 3:15, the promise to Abraham's seed, Jacob's blessing of Judah, and the Isaiah texts do not point to Jesus specifically; that the Mosaic law remains eternally binding; and that the virgin-birth and Bethlehem-birth texts have been misapplied. The second part turns Duran's method into a full system, cataloguing genealogical discrepancies between Matthew and Luke, inconsistencies across the birth, temptation, and resurrection accounts, apparent errors and inconsistencies attributed to Jesus, and what Troki reads as apostolic misquotation of the Hebrew Scriptures.^{ix} When the German Hebraist Johann Christoph Wagenseil published it widely in Latin translation in 1681, meaning to refute it, he instead handed it to the European Enlightenment; Voltaire called it “a masterpiece.”^x

E. The Modern Counter-Missionary Movement (20th–21st c.)

The tradition's current, most organized phase responds directly to the rise of the modern Messianic Jewish movement — *Jews for Jesus*, founded by Moishe Rosen and incorporated in 1973 — which presented faith in Jesus as continuous with, not a departure from, Jewish identity. Organized Jewish institutions rejected that framing outright: a 1993 joint statement by the Jewish Community Relations Council of New York, endorsed by all four major American Jewish denominations, declared that “though Hebrew Christianity claims to be a form of Judaism, it is not.”^{xi}

Rabbi Bentzion Kravitz founded *Jews for Judaism* on August 2, 1985 — its name a deliberate mirror — with a stated mission of “preventing Jews from converting to other faiths and reclaiming those who have already converted,” through counseling, campus outreach, and publication.^{xii} Rabbi Tovia Singer's *Outreach Judaism* and Gerald Sigal's written apologetics, including *The Jew and the Christian Missionary* and *The Trinity: A Counterfeit Doctrine*, extended the same project into books, campus programs, and, today, video. Between them, these voices did not invent new arguments so much as sharpen and popularize the classical ones — with particular energy directed at the doctrine of the Trinity itself, argued not merely mistaken but *idolatrous* — a charge Section III takes up in full.

III. The Case, Fully Stated

Eight arguments make up the substance of the tradition surveyed above. Each is stated here in its strongest form, in the voice of the tradition that holds it.

1. The Suffering Servant Is Israel (Isaiah 53)

The servant of Isaiah's fourth "Servant Song" (52:13–53:12) is Israel personified, not an individual Messiah — and the case is textual, not merely traditional. The three servant songs *preceding* Isaiah 53 explicitly name the servant: "But you, Israel, My servant, Jacob whom I have chosen" (41:8–9); "You are My servant, Israel" (44:1, repeated 44:21; 49:3). Consistency of authorship argues that the fourth song names the same servant as the first three. The chapters immediately surrounding 53 reinforce the point: 52:12 addresses "the Jewish people," and chapter 54's "afflicted, storm-tossed" barren woman restored to bear many children is universally read, even by Christian scholars, as Israel restored from exile. Grammatically, plural forms such as *lamo* in 53:8 point to a group, not one man. Outreach Judaism further notes that this reading predates any Christian objection to it: Origen himself, writing around 248 CE, conceded that the Jewish consensus of his own day already held that the servant meant "the whole people, regarded as one individual."^{xiii}

2. The Royal Line Is Broken

The Messiah must descend from King David through Solomon, *through the father*, per Jewish law's requirement of patrilineal royal descent. Jesus's own claimed genealogy runs through Joseph to Solomon — directly through Jeconiah, a king placed under an explicit and permanent curse in Jeremiah 22:30: "Write this man down childless... for no man of his descendants will succeed in sitting on the throne of David." The Christian claim creates its own trap: if Joseph is Jesus's biological father, the Jeconiah curse disqualifies him from David's throne outright; if the virgin birth is true, Jesus has no biological father at all, and the entire Davidic, patrilineal claim — the one the throne-right actually depends on — collapses with it. Neither branch of the claim delivers a valid king.^{xiv}

3. Maimonides' Test: Confirmed by Results, Not by Claims

No figure in the Jewish tradition states the standard more rigorously, or more famously, than Moses Maimonides (Rambam, 1138–1204) in his legal code, the *Mishneh Torah*. A Davidic king who "diligently contemplates the Torah and observes its mitzvot... compels all of Israel to walk in the way of the Torah... and fights the wars of God" may only *tentatively* be considered Messiah. Confirmation requires results: "If he succeeds in the above, builds the Temple in its place, and gathers the dispersed of Israel, he is definitely

the Mashiach.” Absent that, Maimonides is explicit that even a legitimate, righteous Davidic claimant who dies without achieving it is to be regarded as nothing more than “another of the proper and complete kings of the House of David” who has passed away.^{xv} Maimonides names Jesus specifically as exactly this failed case — a claimant “who aspired to be the Mashiach and was executed by the court” — and goes further, calling the movement that grew from him “a greater stumbling block” that has caused Jewish suffering rather than delivered the promised redemption.^{xvi}

“If he succeeds in the above, builds the Temple in its place, and gathers the dispersed of Israel, he is definitely the Mashiach... If he did not succeed to this degree or was killed, he surely is not the redeemer promised by the Torah.” — Maimonides, Mishneh Torah, Hilchot Melachim 11:4

— A summary of the standard, not a citation from Scripture (NASB95)

4. Elijah Never Came

Malachi 4:5–6 promises that Elijah the prophet will reappear before “the great and terrible day of the LORD” — a fixed, non-negotiable precondition. Christians point to John the Baptist as its fulfillment. But John himself, asked to his face whether he was Elijah, “confessed and did not deny... ‘I am not’” (John 1:20–21) — the New Testament's own witness records the forerunner denying the very identification later Christian doctrine needs him to hold. A precondition denied by its own proposed fulfiller is a precondition unmet.

5. Scripture Knows No Second Coming

Nowhere does the Hebrew Bible describe a Messiah who arrives, is rejected and killed, and then returns at a later, unspecified date to finish the job. Jews for Judaism states the point plainly: biblical prophecy “contains no concept of a returning Messiah.”^{xvii} From outside the Christian tradition, the doctrine of a second coming looks like exactly what a movement facing a fatal problem would need to invent: a promise that the failure is temporary and the payoff still owed, indefinitely deferred beyond any possibility of being checked.

6. Born of a Woman, Not of a Virgin

The claim of miraculous virgin conception rests on a single word, *almah* (Isaiah 7:14), which in ordinary Hebrew usage means simply a young woman of marriageable age — not, specifically or exclusively, a virgin, for which Hebrew has a dedicated word, *betulah*. Read in its own context, Isaiah 7 is a sign given to King Ahaz *for his own lifetime* — a child conceived in the ordinary way, whose growth to the age of moral discernment would mark the timeline before Ahaz's two enemy kings fell, not a prophecy reaching seven centuries forward. Isaac of Troki catalogued the New Testament's own birth accounts as further evidence the claim was constructed after the fact rather than transmitted reliably: Matthew's and Luke's genealogies and infancy narratives do not agree with each other on the route to David, and the *Toledot*

Yeshu tradition preserves the community's memory that the true story behind the miraculous claim was an ordinary, and scandalous, one.^{xviii}

7. The Test of a True Prophet (Deuteronomy 13 and 18)

Deuteronomy sets two tests, and Jesus fails both. Deuteronomy 13:1–5 is explicit that a prophet or dreamer who performs a genuine sign or wonder must still be rejected, and put to death, if his message leads Israel toward worshiping *other gods* — the miracle itself is treated as a test of loyalty, not proof of legitimacy. A movement that calls a man divine and directs worship to him alongside the Father meets that description regardless of any wonders reported of him. Deuteronomy 18:20–22 adds a second, falsifiable test: a prophet who speaks presumptuously in God's name, whose word does not come to pass, is not to be feared — he was never sent. Jesus's own recorded prediction that “this generation will not pass away until all these things take place” (Matthew 24:34) has now gone unfulfilled for two thousand years, a plain, first-order case of exactly the failure Deuteronomy 18 warns against.^{xix}

8. Echad: One, Not Three

The Shema — “Hear, O Israel: the LORD is our God, the LORD is *one*” (Deuteronomy 6:4) — recited twice daily, bound on the arm and forehead, fixed to the doorpost, is the single most central confession in Jewish life. Its claim is not merely that there is one God rather than many; it is that God's oneness is not divided into persons, natures, or any internal plurality that could seat a second (or third) figure within it as an object of worship. To bow to Jesus as divine is, on this reading, not a refinement of Israel's monotheism but a direct violation of the first and second commandments — idolatry, however sincerely intended. Rabbi Tovia Singer has made this argument a centerpiece of his teaching and, in Gerald Sigal's phrase for a book-length treatment of the same claim, the Trinity itself is *a counterfeit doctrine* — a later theological invention read back into a text that never taught it, imported substantially from the surrounding Greco-Roman philosophical world rather than drawn from Israel's own Scripture.^{xx}

Hear, O Israel! The LORD is our God, the LORD is one!

— Deuteronomy 6:4 (NASB95)

IV. A Living Tradition, Not a Relic

It would be a mistake to read everything above as ancient history. Nachmanides, Duran, and Troki wrote under duress that this ministry does not minimize — forced disputation, forced baptism, and, in later centuries, worse. But the tradition they built did not stop with them. Rabbi Tovia Singer fills auditoriums and, now, video platforms; Jews for Judaism runs active campus programs; Gerald Sigal's books remain in print and in active use. This is a live, contemporary, intellectually serious position held by thoughtful people, not a museum piece preserved only to be refuted.

That has a direct bearing on how a Christian reader ought to hold this material. The purpose of stating the case this fully is not academic completeness for its own sake. It is so that when a Christian actually encounters a Jewish friend, colleague, or interlocutor who raises one of these eight arguments, the response is not surprise, and not a straw man swatted down — it is recognition, and the beginning of a real conversation.

V. Conclusion and Further Study

Eight arguments, five historical stages, one throughline: a serious, developing, internally coherent tradition of Jewish thought that has taken the question of Yeshua's messiahship with complete seriousness and, generation after generation, answered *no*. Readers who want to see how Christian and Messianic Jewish scholarship has responded to each of these eight arguments in turn are directed to this paper's companion volume, *A Case for He Is the Messiah*. But that volume is not required reading to have understood *this* one. This one stands on its own, because understanding the case fully, before any answer is offered, was the entire point.

For Further Study

- [Deuteronomy 6:4-9 — the Shema](#)
- [Isaiah 53 — the Servant Song at the heart of objection 1](#)
- [Jeremiah 22:24-30 — the curse on Jeconiah](#)
- [Deuteronomy 13 and 18:15-22 — the tests of a prophet](#)

Primary Sources Worth Reading Directly

- Isaac of Troki, Chizzuk Emunah (Faith Strengthened), 16th c. — full text available at juchre.org/emunah.
- Ramban (Nachmanides), The Disputation at Barcelona, trans. Charles B. Chavel.
- Maimonides, Mishneh Torah, Hilchot Melachim, chapters 11-12 — available in translation at Chabad.org.
- Gerald Sigal, The Jew and the Christian Missionary and The Trinity: A Counterfeit Doctrine.
- Outreach Judaism (outreachjudaism.org) and Jews for Judaism (jewsforjudaism.org) — the two leading contemporary counter-missionary organizations, in their own words.

- ⁱWikipedia, "Dialogue with Trypho," accessed September 2026, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dialogue_with_Trypho.
- ⁱⁱOn the dating and disputed identification of the Yeshu passages, see "Which Talmudic Passages Are Argued To Refer To Jesus," factually.co, accessed September 2026, <https://factually.co/fact-checks/religion/talmudic-passages-referenced-as-jesus-evidence-pros-cons-880f39>.
- ⁱⁱⁱWikipedia, "Toledot Yeshu," accessed September 2026, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Toledot_Yeshu.
- ^{iv}Wikipedia, "Disputation of Barcelona," accessed September 2026, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Disputation_of_Barcelona.
- ^vNachmanides's argument as recounted in "The Disputation of Ramban (Nachmanides)," Chabad.org, accessed September 2026, https://www.chabad.org/library/article_cdo/aid/4612923/jewish/The-Disputation-of-Ramban-Nachmanides.htm.
- ^{vi}Nachmanides, quoted in Wikipedia, "Disputation of Barcelona."
- ^{vii}Wikipedia, "Disputation of Barcelona."
- ^{viii}Wikipedia, "Profiat Duran," accessed September 2026, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Profiat_Duran.
- ^{ix}Table of contents summarized from "JCR — Chizuk Emunah, Isaac ben Abraham of Troki," juchre.org, accessed September 2026, <https://juchre.org/emunah/emunahtoc.htm>.
- ^xWikipedia, "Isaac of Troki," accessed September 2026, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Isaac_of_Troki.
- ^{xi}Wikipedia, "Jews for Jesus," accessed September 2026, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Jews_for_Jesus.
- ^{xii}Wikipedia, "Jews for Judaism," accessed September 2026, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Jews_for_Judaism.
- ^{xiii}Outreach Judaism, "Who Is God's Suffering Servant? The Rabbinic Interpretation of Isaiah 53," accessed September 2026, <https://outreachjudaism.org/gods-suffering-servant-isaiah-53/>.
- ^{xiv}This objection is summarized at Jews for Judaism, "The Jewish Concept of Messiah and the Jewish Response to Christian Claims," accessed September 2026, <https://jewsforjudaism.org/knowledge/articles/the-jewish-concept-of-messiah-and-the-jewish-response-to-christian-claims/>.
- ^{xv}Maimonides, Mishneh Torah, Hilchot Melachim 11:4, quoted from the Chabad.org translation, "Melachim uMilchamot — Chapter 11," accessed September 2026, https://www.chabad.org/library/article_cdo/aid/1188356/jewish/Melachim-uMilchamot-Chapter-11.htm.
- ^{xvi}Maimonides, Mishneh Torah, Hilchot Melachim, quoted from Chabad.org, "Melachim uMilchamot — Chapter 11."
- ^{xvii}Jews for Judaism, "The Jewish Concept of Messiah and the Jewish Response to Christian Claims."
- ^{xviii}Chapter-content summary drawn from "JCR — Chizuk Emunah," juchre.org; narrative summary from Wikipedia, "Toledot Yeshu."
- ^{xix}On the Deuteronomy 13 test generally, see the discussion of Joseph Bekhor Shor's medieval application of it to claims of magic and false prophecy in "Can a False Prophet Perform Miracles?" thetorah.com, accessed September 2026, <https://www.thetorah.com/article/can-a-false-prophet-perform-miracles>.
- ^{xx}On Tovia Singer's teaching and Gerald Sigal, The Trinity: A Counterfeit Doctrine, see the discussion at Christian Research Institute, "Deuteronomy 6:4 and the Trinity: How Can Jews and Christians Both Embrace the 'Echad' of the Shema?" accessed September 2026, <https://www.equip.org/articles/deuteronomy-64-trinity-can-jews-christians-embrace-echad-shema/>.